

Nordheim

TOWERS OF SAEROTH · PLAYER HANDOUT

Honour, hospitality, and perseverance. Great deeds are kept in song and in telling rather than in writing, and every Nordheimer works to leave behind a saga worth the keeping. A hard death is not the thing they are afraid of. A forgotten life is.

- **Founded** c. 1180 AR, when the Great Thing was first recorded, three centuries before the kingship. Jarls met at the same fjord to settle blood-debt long before they agreed to elect anybody, and the High King's authority still stops where the assembly says.
- **Capital** Hravnfjord, a deepwater harbor town that swells fourfold whenever the Great Thing is called
- **Geography** Fjords, taiga, and whale coasts; the interior is mountain and the sea is the road
- **Government** Four ranks, not always all filled. A **chief** holds a town. A **jarl** stands over several chiefs from a fortified hall. A **king** may stand over many jarls from a hall no grander — the rank exists and often sits empty. Chief, jarl and king are hereditary; the **High King** is not. He is elected at the Great Thing from the sitting jarls and kings, regardless of ancestry, and the Thing caps his authority the same way. His own jarldom still passes to his heir, so a dead king's son is a jarl by morning and stands for election like anyone else. One house can hold the crown three reigns running and never hold it by right. A jarldom with no heir is filled by the Thing
- **Races** Humans, Dwarves, Jotun — mostly Jotun in the far north, mostly human in the south, which is about the cold and nothing else. Rank is open to either: a jarl is a jarl everywhere, and eleven of the twenty-six High Kings since c. 1520 have been Jotun
- **Naming** Old Norse and Gaelic mixed freely, patronymics not surnames. Norse is the Jotun half, Gaelic came north with the human founders, and nobody sorts them anymore. Sigrún Ketilsdóttir, Hravn Bjarnsson, Ronan Hravnsson, Aífe Ketilsdóttir
- **Faith** Patron Cayden Cailean, god of bravery, freedom and the guest-cup, which is the closest thing Nordheim has to a national creed. Gorum is kept for war and Desna for the long voyages; the oldest sagas still invoke Trudd
- **Economic Specialties** Timber, furs, amber, iron, shipbuilding, whaling
- **Military** Shield walls, berserkers, longship fleets, elite axemen, mountain scouts. Over any of it stands a **war chief** — a command, not a title. Whoever leads Nordheimers under arms holds it while it lasts, from a six-oar crew to the whole nation's strength. A jarl or chief usually takes it for their own raiders; if not, the warband names someone who can. In a national war the High King commonly takes it himself and fights beside the men he called up
- **History** Founded twice. The human half fled the Stoneborn Holds' northern field-holdings after the winter of c. 1124, when the gates stayed shut for eleven weeks and a third died on the road — see The Shut Gate. The Jotun clans took them in, taught them the sea, and got metallurgy, rank and the raid back. Joined neither crown in the Two-Crown War and raided both coasts for nine years. Nordheim got rich, and they remember it better than Nordheim does. Signed the Pilgrim's Peace four years late, after a Thing argument, and has kept it without complaint since.
- **Reputation** Stoic explorers, fierce warriors, and steadfast allies
- **Tension** The High King is dying and the Great Thing must be called before the ice closes the fjords, which means the jarls who arrive late will have no say at all
- **Relations** — in brief; every tie in full, and the web, are in Political Relations
 - Stoneborn Holds — **Allied**: An alliance built over a grave, and worth a great deal to both anyway: Nordheim's founders were the Holds' field-hands until a winter the gates stayed shut against them. ...

- Kesmarch Frontier — **Friendly:** Half the frontier's charters are held by second sons out of the fjords, and the Territorial Council still runs its founding assembly on Nordheim's Thing procedure
- Khazan Khaganate — **Friendly:** Two warrior codes that have never had cause to test each other, an ocean apart. ...
- Corvane Republic — **Trade:** Nordheim timber and amber into the Vantry yards, Corvane hulls back north. ...
- Thurion Merchant Alliance — **Trade:** The northern run — timber and whale oil, in the season when it can be sailed at all
- Undertide Reaches — **Trade:** Amber and whale oil down into the deep holds, deep-vein iron back up. ...
- Aquoniti — **Rivalry:** Two seafaring peoples who each consider themselves the ones who invented it, separated by enough ocean to keep the argument theoretical
- Elven Confederacy — **Territorial:** Nordheim logging camps in the northern pine, on the Confederacy's own frontier and inside ground the tribes have marked for eleven centuries. ...

You cannot repeat any of this. Not to the party, not on paper, not in stone.

The Shut Gate

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Before there was a Nordheim there were farmers on the cold side of the Stoneborn Holds, and they were not there by choice.

A hold is a city with no fields. Highforge and the deep cities under it could cut steel but not grow oats. So the valleys on the mountain's northern skirts were worked for them, by people the Assembly's records call the field-holdings and never call anything else. They were cattle-keepers and oat-growers who fostered their children between families and kept their dead in praise-songs. Half of Nordheim's given names sound nothing like the other half because of it.

The arrangement lasted centuries and was not slavery in any thane's telling. The quota was set at the Assembly and rose in bad years, because bad years were when the holds needed most, and a family that missed it lost the holding. It was all written down. It is still in the ledgers, in a clear hand.

The winter of 1124

It came early and it did not break. The oats had already failed. By the turn of the year the northern valleys were burning fence-rails and eating seed corn, and the field-holdings went up the road to Highforge and asked to be let in until spring.

The gates stayed shut.

They stayed shut for eleven weeks. What the Assembly said at the time is recorded and is not unreasonable: the holds were on short commons themselves, and the grain that would have fed the farmers was the grain keeping Highforge's furnace crews alive. The thanes debated it properly and voted, and they wrote down that they had.

Nobody knows how many died on the road. Nordheim's count is one in three and Nordheim has never had any way to check it.

The going north

What came down off that mountain in the spring was not farmers. They took what they needed from the first steadings they reached and kept going, north and then east along the coast. For something like a generation they were nothing anyone would call a people — a moving column that fed itself by arriving. They got good at it fast.

They reached the fjords in about 1150 and found them held.

The Jotun

The Jotunborn clans of the far north had been there beyond any reckoning, fishing the cold water and hunting the ice and keeping to themselves so thoroughly that most of the continent took them for a rumour rather than a people. They were not gentle and they were not warlike. They had never met anything worth fighting, and the north had made them hard enough that nothing had tried twice.

They took the column in. The sagas are unhelpfully brief about why. The first winter, the clans fed a starving people they had no reason to feed. The incomers had been told for two hundred years that this did not happen.

Then each side taught the other what it had.

The Jotun gave the sea: which water fishes, which ice holds, where the whale run turns, how to be out in weather that kills. Everything Nordheim is famous for on the water it learned in a clan boat.

The incomers gave the forge and the war. They had two centuries of watching dwarven metallurgy from the wrong side of it, and had gone hungry rather than stupid: they arrived knowing how to make steel, move men in ranks, and hold ground by agreement rather than argument. The Jotun took all three, and raiding suited them at once.

Within four generations you could not sort the two by their habits, only by their height.

The names went the same way and went further. The clans already spoke the hard northern tongue that gives Nordheim its patronymics, so a stranger who assumes the whole Norse half of the country is the human half has it backwards — the incomers brought the softer names, and what they found waiting was Ketilsdóttir and Bjarnsson. The two stocks never sorted themselves out. A Gaelic given name on a Jotun patronymic raises no eyebrow, and half the fjords are crewed by men called things like Ronan Hravnsen without anyone hearing two languages in it.

The Thing

The government came out of the same seam. Jotun clans had no chiefs. They kept key roles — chroniclers, keepers, scouts — and when a decision was needed the seniors of those roles met and voted. A senior outmatched by a younger hand stepped down to apprentice without anyone thinking it strange. The incomers had the opposite inheritance: heritable rank, sworn obligation, and a clear notion of who answers to whom, passing from a father to whoever he had got.

The Great Thing at Hravnfjord in c. 1180 is those two things bolted together, and it still shows the join. Rank is heritable and held for life — chief, jarl and king alike — which came up the road with the incomers. The assembly can overrule any jarl including the High King, which came out of the clans. That is why the High King's authority stops where the Thing says it does and never creeps.

The seam runs right through the crown. Every seat in Nordheim passes from father to heir except the one at the top, which is filled by a vote and was never anybody's to leave. A dead High King's son inherits his father's jarldom and nothing more, and stands at the next Thing on the same footing as every other jarl in the hall. Houses have held the crown three reigns running on the strength of being worth electing. None has ever held it by right. The clans who made that rule had spent their whole history watching seniors step down when a younger hand outmatched them.

Even the word for the lowest rung is borrowed. Nordheim's chiefs hold towns, and the clans that had never had a chief in their lives took the title for a job they had never needed until they were living in towns worth holding.

What did not survive the welding was any notion of whose seat is whose. Nordheim has one government and has never had two. A jarl is a jarl, inherited on the same terms in every jarldom, and eleven of the twenty-six High Kings crowned since c. 1520 have been Jotun. Nobody in the fjords keeps that count. A Corvane pamphleteer worked it out and found it remarkable. The Thing's own rolls don't record ancestry at all, because no procedure has ever needed to ask.

What is remembered

The far northern jarldoms are mostly Jotun and the southern ones mostly human, a fact about where the cold is and nothing else. They have been marrying, crewing and voting together for nine centuries. A northern jarl speaks for the humans in his jarldom and a southern one for the Jotun in his, and neither half regards the other as incomers. Ask which, and you'll be told the question is stupid.

Two things in Nordheim make no sense without this and are never explained with it. The first is Cayden Cailean, god of bravery, freedom, and the guest-cup — a national creed that comes down to *you open the door*, kept by a people descended from those who were left outside one. The second is that hospitality in the north is not a courtesy but a law with teeth, and a jarl who turns away a traveller in winter can be brought before the Thing for it.

The Stoneborn Holds and Nordheim are **allied**, and have been for centuries; the iron road between them is worth a great deal to both. The Holds consider the matter closed and closed honourably. The ledgers are open to anyone who asks and nothane has ever pretended otherwise. Nordheim has never asked for an apology, which the thanes have sometimes mistaken for the thing being forgotten.

It is not forgotten. It is in a song every child in the fjords knows, and the song is not about dwarves. It is about a door.

See Nordheim, Stoneborn Holds and Ages of Saeroth.

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